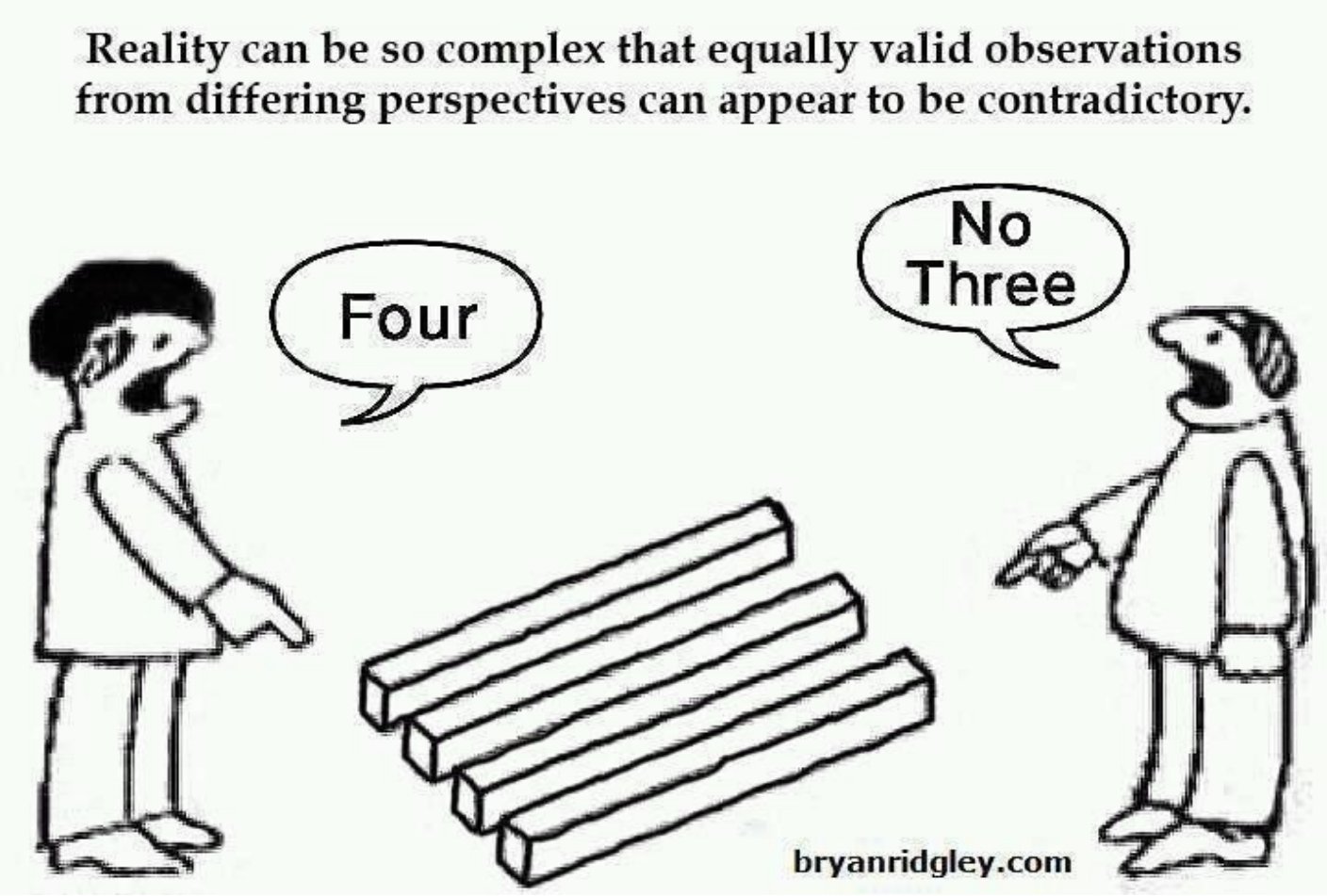
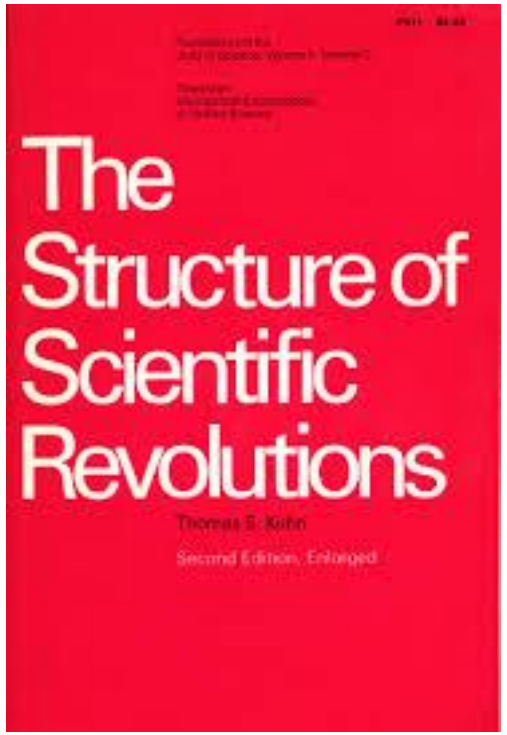
Sociological Research



Asking and answering sociological questions

The development of scientific knowledge

- Development of scientific knowledge through research- gradual and cumulative.
- Thomas Kuhn [1962]: **“Paradigm”**, a general model of the world that is accepted by most research practioners
- Scientific revolution and paradigm shift
- **Sociology**: as a multi-paradigm field



The social research process

1. Uncover questions in need of answers
2. Review of literature
3. Formulating a hypothesis
4. Selecting a research design
5. Carrying out research
6. Analysis and interpretation
7. Reporting research findings

Examples of sociological research questions

- Using Durkheim's work on suicide, you would like to examine if social networking can prevent suicide
- Hypotheses?
- Method?

- **Hypothesis 1**: Those who have many FB friends are more socially integrated and hence *less likely* to commit suicide than those who have fewer FB friends or not on FB at all
- **Hypothesis 2**: No matter how many friends one has on FB, those who have few friends in the "real world" are *more likely* to commit suicide

Issues in social research

- **Reliability**
  - Involves the degree to which a given question or a measure produces more or less same results on repeated examinations
- **Validity**
  - Does the question measure what it is supposed to measure? (e.g. getting a valid measurement of how religious one is)
  - How would you measure one's social class?
- **Ethics**

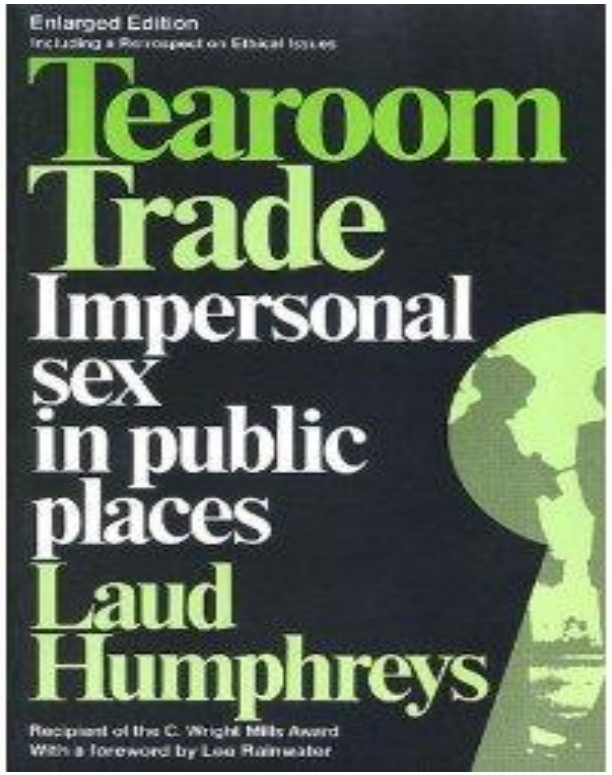
Ethics and studying human subjects

Whether research "**poses risks to the subjects that are greater than the risks they face in their everyday lives**"

<u>Laud Humphreys, 1970</u>

"Tearoom trade" (U.S)

"Cottaging" (U.K)

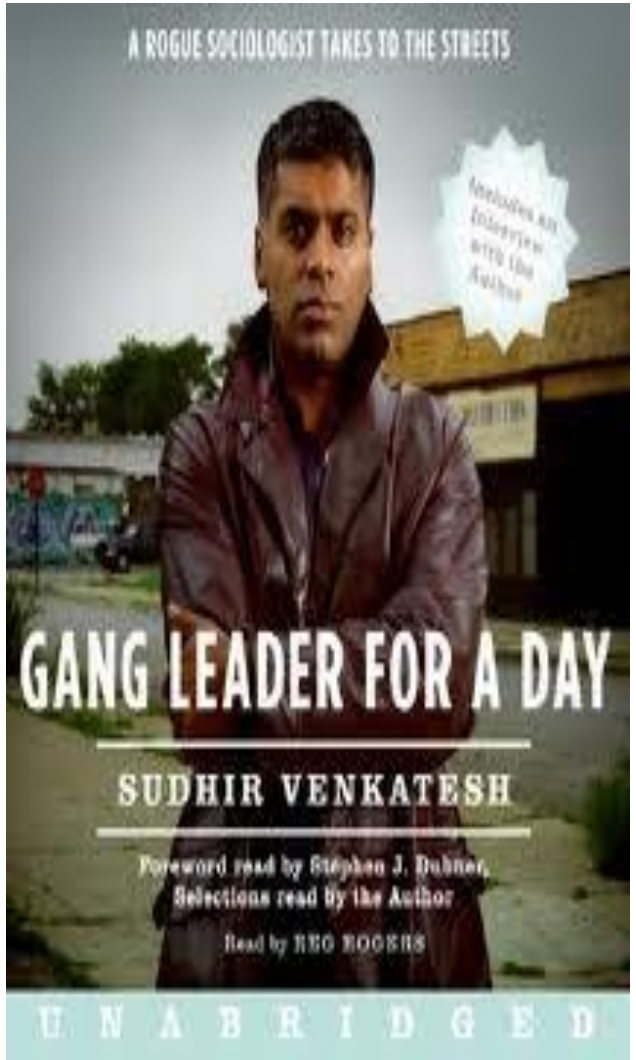


Contribution of Humphrey's highly controversial study

- One of the first studies to look at homosexual interactions
- Highlighted struggles and stigma of peoples with alternative identities/sexualities
- Highlighted the incongruity between private self and social self
- The "ethics" question of social science research

Another example
“Gang Leader for a Day”, Sudhir Venkatesh

- Gang behavior/ urban poverty in a drug-dealing community of Chicago



Medical “ethics”: An earlier example

- **The Tuskagee Syphilis Study** (1932-1972)
  - Conducted by the United States Public Health Service
  - On African American impoverished sharecroppers in Alabama
  - Cure for syphilis (penicillin) had been invented in 1947
  - Subjects were denied treatment and cure
  - “**To study the natural course of the disease until death**”
  - Public apology that acknowledged the wrongdoing came in 1997
  - (Bio)Medical research and “**informed consent**”

Medic

Medical Ethics

- Henrietta Lacks' was responsible for advances in research on cancer, though without her knowledge.
- 2017 HBO movie *The Immortal Life of Henrietta Lacks*

Medical research in the Third World

- “Research in the Third World looks relatively attractive as it becomes **better funded** and **regulations at home become more restrictive**. The fact remains that many studies are still done in the Third World simply could not be done in the countries sponsoring the work. Clinical trials have become **a big business**. To survive, it is necessary to get the work **done as quickly** as possible, with a minimum of obstacles”

Marcia Angell [Editor, *New England Journal of Medicine,* 2000]

Asking sociological questions

- Two requirements-
- *Apply the sociological perspective* – what are the curious patterns around us that call for further study.
- *Be curious and ask questions*.

- You could ask questions along different lines- think about advancement in girls' education in India. What questions will you ask?

Sociologist's line of questioning (e.g. girls' education)

Factual questions (empirical)	What happened?	Since the 1980s, girls have been attaining better educational results in school than boys
Comparative questions	Does this happen everywhere	Was this is a global phenomenon?
Developmental questions	Has this happened overtime	What have been the patterns of girls' educational outcomes overtime
Theoretical questions	What underlies this phenomenon	What are the factors that may explain this trend

Variables in social science research

- **Independent**
  - Produces an effect on another variable
- **Dependent**
  - The variable that is affected
- **Controls**
  - Variables that are held constant to "screen out" other possible influences

Quantitative versus Qualitative methods

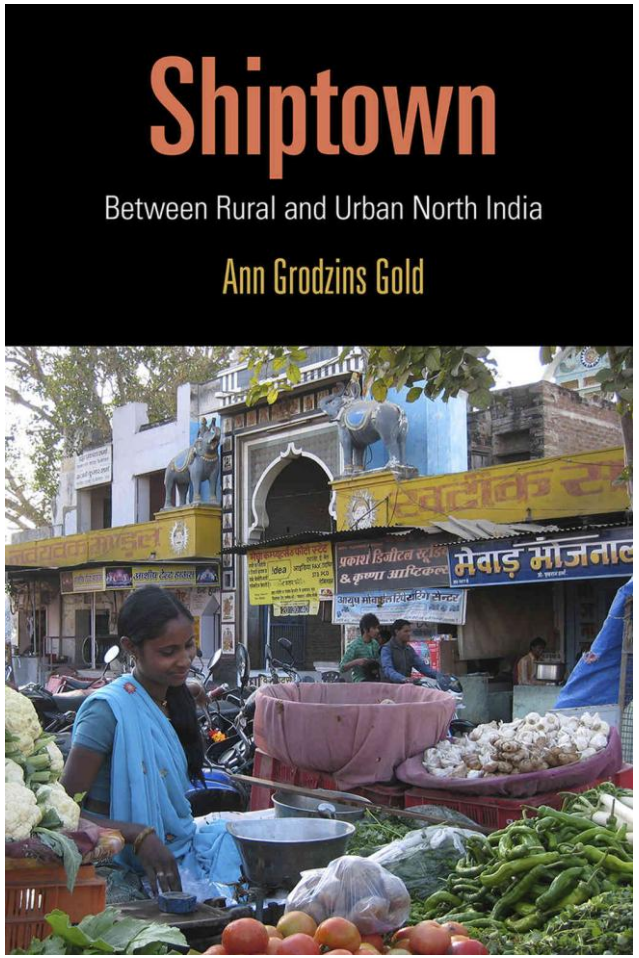
- **Quantitative:**
  - measure social phenomena
  - Mathematical models, statistical analyses
- **Qualitative**
  - Detailed, rich data, in-depth understanding
- **Mixed methods**

Types of research methods/designs

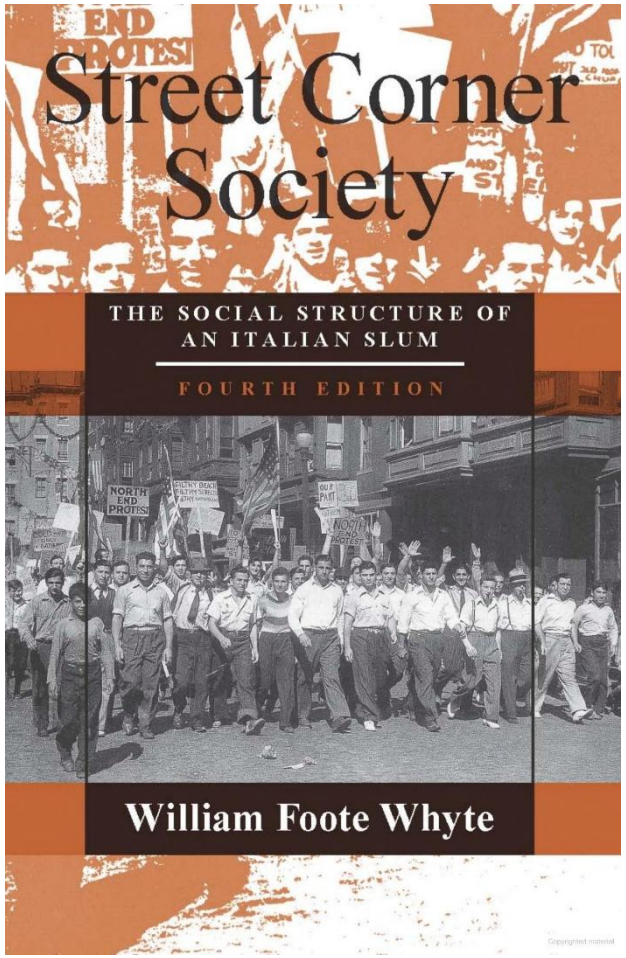
- Ethnography and participant observation
- Surveys
- Experiments
- Biographical
- Comparative and Historical

Ethnography

- “Ethnography is the telling of people’s story”
- **Tools**: interviews, participant observation, focus groups
- In-depth knowledge & understanding of social phenomena
- **Examples**: “Tearoom trade”, “gang leader for a day”



Source: https://www.sahapedia.org/conversation-ann-gold-and-bhojuram-gujar-women-who-sing-gods-rajasthan



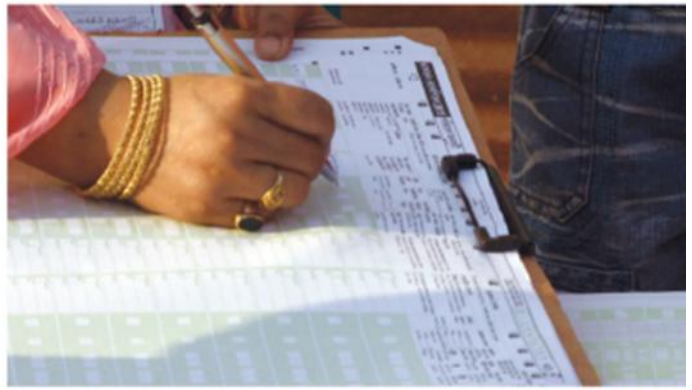
- A Sociological Classic by William Foote Whyte

Limitations of ethnographic studies

- Only small groups or communities can be studied
- Too much dependent on the researcher’s skill
- Loss of objectivity

Surveys

1. Collecting data on large number of people
2. Administered by government agencies, research organizations, market research groups
3. Tools: Questionnaires (standardized/close ended, open ended)



Advantages and Disadvantages of Surveys

- **Advantages**
  - Easily quantifiable
  - Large number of people; generalization
  - High degree of anonymity
- **Disadvantages**
  - Less depth and substance
  - Non-response
  - May force responses

Experiments

- Investigating *cause and effect*.
- Begin with a hypothesis- a statement of a possible relationship between variables.
- Examples: The Stanford County Prison
- *Prison setting*- independent variable; *Violence*: Dependent Variable.
- What would be the hypothesis?
- What did Zimbardo find?

wood City Tribune AD No. 499, include phone no.

Male college students needed for psychological study of prison life. $15 per day for 1-2 weeks beginning Aug. 14. For further information & applications, come to Room 248, Jordan Hall, Stanford U.

TELEPHONE CONTACTS
Sell security systems. New air cond. office, parking. Exc. location & understanding boss. $1.75 + comm. Call Mr. Nelson, 323-1339.
Killmurray, 592-3950.

The awareness of being studied

- Hawthorne Effect
- Hypothesis: Increasing the available lighting would raise productivity.
- Independent variable: lighting
- Dependent variable: output/worker productivity

Biographical Research

- Used to explore how individuals experience social life and periods of social change
- Oral histories, narratives, autobiographies, life histories
- Based on people's memories

Comparative Historical Research

- *Time perspective* from a comparative standpoint
- Tools: diaries, policy documents, records of births, deaths, tax records; newspapers/magazines of a particular period
- **Example**: documentaries and books on Holocaust survivors
- Partition stories

A Tale of Two Cities

- Using available data to do research.
- E Digby Baltzell's (1979) *Puritan Boston and Quaker Philadelphia*
- Why did one of these cities had more famous people?
- The answer lay in religious differences between the two places.

Four Research Methods

	Experiment	Survey	Participant Observation	Existing Sources
Application	For explanatory research that specifies relationships between variables Generates quantitative data	For gathering information about issues that cannot be directly observed, such as attitudes and values Useful for descriptive and explanatory research Generates quantitative or qualitative data	For exploratory and descriptive study of people in a "natural" setting Generates qualitative data	For exploratory, descriptive, or explanatory research whenever suitable data are available
Advantages	Provides the greatest opportunity to specify cause-and-effect relationships Replication of research is relatively easy.	Sampling, using questionnaires, allows surveys of large populations. Interviews provide in-depth responses.	Allows study of "natural" behavior Usually inexpensive	Saves time and expense of data collection Makes historical research possible
Limitations	Laboratory settings have an artificial quality. Unless the research environment is carefully controlled, results may be biased.	Questionnaires must be carefully prepared and may yield a low return rate. Interviews are expensive and time-consuming.	Time-consuming Replication of research is difficult. Researcher must balance roles of participant and observer.	Researcher has no control over possible biases in data. Data may only partially fit current research needs.

Exercise: Indicate suitable methods for collecting data

1. An exploration of attitudes towards drug abuse in one country
2. The experience of being an hostage victim
3. Significance of social/kinship networks in working-class culture
4. Why do people join political parties?
5. Experiences of parents deciding which school to send their kid to in Delhi
6. What other questions would you like to research?

Objectivity or value-free sociology: Is it possible?

Not quite.
Effort should be taken to make the **data collection process unbiased**. Interpretations are often shaped by researchers' assumptions, own lived experiences and social positions. Need for transparency.